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HOW TO TRAIN YOUR NEW PET

A comprehensive step-by-step guide on how to train your new furry friend!

YEAR 12 ATAR PSYCHOLOGY

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INTRODUCTION

The purpose of this manual to familiarise yourself with training methods that can be directly applied to your new furry friend. This manual aims to guide you through the hardships of pet ownership.

There are three theories and processes of learning that will be mentioned in this guide. These theories were developed by trustworthy psychologists and can be directly applied to training any pet. Classical conditioning and operant conditioning are types of associative learning processes. Associative learning can be defined as *the process of a new response developing an association with a particular stimulus.* Observational learning is a process of learning by observing others.

Through applying these methods of training, you should be able to train your pet to do whatever you want them to do. For example, operant conditioning can be applied to your pet by rewarding them with a walk after they learn to sit when putting the leash on.

The following pages will go in-depth about each learning theory and how it can be directly applied to training your furry friend.

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LEARNING

Learning is the acquisition of knowledge or skills through study, experience or being taught. It is a change in behaviour as a result of experience through external stimuli. It is a relatively permanent change.

Stimuli are any type of object or event that triggers a response. For example, the smell or sound of food being prepared for your dog.

Responses are identified behaviours that are caused by stimuli. For example, your dog salivating in response to hearing or smelling food being prepared for him.

The central component to learning is reinforcement as it encourages desired behaviour to occur. For this behaviour to occur, a positive reinforcer such as a treat must be given to the pet after their behaviour. The same principle can be applied to unwanted behaviour, but instead replacing the positive reinforcer with a negative reinforcer such as squirting them with a little amount of water.

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THEORIES OF LEARNING
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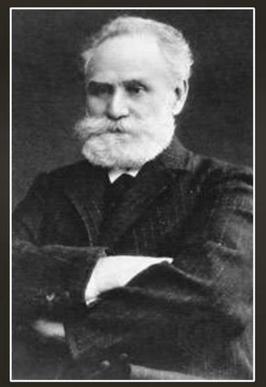
CLASSICAL CONDITIONING



Classical Conditioning was one of the earliest learning theories and originated in the 20th century by Russian physiologist, Ivan Pavlov. At the time, Pavlov was researching digestive processes within dogs when he accidentally discovered a phenomenon that what was later called 'psychic reflexes.' Pavlov utilised his discovery to further develop the theory of Classical Conditioning through experimenting with dogs.

Classical Conditioning was first discovered in animals, as they displayed an established association between two stimuli. For this to occur, the animal must learn the association between the two stimuli for a response (also know as a reflex) to occur. Associative leaning is a biological advantage as it can be utilised to escape encounters with predators or dangerous environments.

For example, an animal can learn the association between leaves rustling and sticks breaking in bushes with a lurking predator hiding, ready to attack.. This would cause the animal to flee and run away for survival.

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CLASSICAL CONDITIONING

In summary, classical conditioning involves two or more stimuli being repeatedly paired together to elicit an anticipated, reflexive response. Classical Conditioning occurs in three different stages:

Stage 1: Before Conditioning

There must be a natural association between two stimuli for conditioning to occur. These stimuli are the unconditioned stimulus (UCS) and an involuntary behaviour called the unconditioned response (UCR). For example, the animal running away (UCR) after spotting a predator (UCS) in the wild. Therefore, the unconditioned stimulus is causing the unconditioned response.

Stage 2: During Conditioning

A neutral stimulus (NS) is introduced, which is repeatedly presented after the unconditioned stimulus. This repetition establishes a conditioned response (CR). For example, rustling of branches is introduced as the neutral stimulus. Overtime, the animal will associate the branches rustling (NS) with the predator (UCS). This means that the animal has learnt that when the branches are rustled, the predator will jump out and attack.

Stage 3: After Conditioning

Once the association is made, the neutral stimulus becomes the conditioned stimulus (CS) and the unconditioned response becomes the conditioned response (CR). This means that the CR is the natural response to when the CS is presented. For example, the animal will flee whenever it hears the branches rustling. This will occur even if a predator doesn't jump out of the bushes as it has associated the noise of branches rustling to a predator. Running away becomes the conditioned response (CR) and is caused by the rustling bushes which is the conditioned stimulus (CS)

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CLASSICAL CONDITIONING

The five key principles of Classical Conditioning:

Acquisition – where learning is initially established: the neutral stimulus is repeatedly paired with an unconditioned stimulus. After an association is established, a response will be emitted in response to the neutral stimulus, which has now shifted to be the conditioned stimulus. It can be said that a response has now been acquired. Acquisition is strengthened through repetition.

Extinction – when the conditioned stimulus is reduced, resulting in the association being forgotten or the conditioned response decreasing in strength. This means that the conditioned stimulus is no longer paired with an unconditioned stimulus.

Spontaneous Recovery – the sudden re-emergence of a conditioned response after a period of time where the conditioned stimuli was no longer applied to the subject.

Stimulus Generalisation – the tendency for the conditioned stimulus to evoke a similar response other than the conditioned response. The response resembles the original stimulus, but is not the same.

Stimulus Discrimination - the ability to differentiate between the conditioned stimulus and stimuli have not been previously paired with the unconditioned stimulus. This results in a response only to the conditioned stimulus. For example, the animal not responding to the sound of the trees in the wind, and only responding to the rustling bushes which has been associated with a lurking predator.

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EVIDENCE FOR CLASSICAL CONDITIONING

PAVLOV'S DOG STUDY

As mentioned previously, Pavlov was a Russian physiologist whom was studying the role of saliva in digestive processes of dogs when he discovered 'psychic reflexes.' In 1899, he performed an experiment to test a dog's salivation levels when presented with meat powder. Pavlov surgically implanted a tube into the dogs salivary glands to measure salivation. Initially, the dogs salivated only when presented with the powder. Overtime, he noticed that dogs began to salivate before the powder was administered, and he was fascinated by what caused this 'psychic reflex.'

Pavlov began to to pair the meat powder with the ringing of a bell. The auditory stimulus and meat powder were presented multiple times until Pavlov decided to present the sound of the bell alone. The dog's responded to the sound by salivating, even when they weren't presented with the sight or aroma of the food.

In Pavlov's experiment, the unconditioned stimulus (UCS) is the food and the uncontrolled response is the salivation when presented with food. The neutral stimulus was the bell, due to the fact that it had no association with the UCS before it was learned. After the association was learnt, the ringing of the bell became the conditioned stimulus and the conditioned response was salivation as it occurred when the UCS is not present.

<u>Pavlov's findings became the basis of classical conditioning and associative learning</u>

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EVIDENCE FOR CLASSICAL CONDITIONING

LITTLE ALBERT STUDY

J.B. Watson performed an experiment (1920) in which a fear response was conditioned in a young child nicknamed 'Little Albert'. Watson aimed to investigate the role of associative learning on fear acquisition through classical conditioning.

Little Albert was presented a white rat, in which he showed no fear towards. The rat was repeatedly paired with a loud noise which elicited fear from the boy through crying. This was repeated multiple times until Little Albert learned that each time he was presented with a white rat, a loud noise was occur afterwards. This caused a fear of white fluffy animals such as the rat.

In this experiment, the white right was the neutral stimulus, the loud noise was the unconditioned stimulus and Albert's fear was the unconditioned response. After conditioning, the white rat became the conditioned stimulus and Albert's fear became the conditioned response.

This experiment supports classical conditioning, as Little Albert learned to associate the white rat with the loud noises. This therefore supports the theory that people learn through natural association and therefore, experiences.

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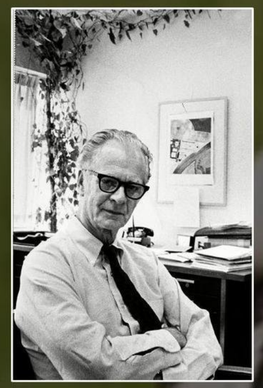
OPERANT CONDITIONING



Operant Conditioning was established by the behaviourist B.F. Skinner in the late 1930s. Skinner believed that the cause of human behaviour was external and observable. Skinner was influenced by the work of Edward Thorndike, who proposed Thorndike's 'Law of Effect' in 1898. This law stated that animals repeat responses that are rewarded and drop other responses that are punished in some way.

Operant conditioning is the process of associative learning whereby an individual associates their behaviour with it's consequences through the use of rewards and punishments. Operant behaviours are followed with a response, which can be a reward, punishment or nothing at all to induce a desired response. Reinforcement encourages the desired behaviour, whereas punishments are aimed to suppress the unwanted behaviour.

Operant behaviours are the behaviours under our conscious control in which the consequences of these actions influence whether they occur again or not. For example, if you study hard and get a good score in an assessment, you will be more likely to study hard for an assessment again in the future.

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OPERANT CONDITIONING

In summary, operant conditioning involves the association of behaviour with its consequences, such as a reward, punishment or no consequence at all. This association forms the basis of whether or not the behaviour will be performed again in the future or not at all. Operant conditioning focuses on voluntary responses whereas classical conditioning is concerned with involuntary responses. This is how it works:

Step 1: Behaviour

The operant behaviour occurs, which is under the organism's conscious control. The consequences to this behaviour govern whether the operant behaviour occurs again. For example, a student tells a funny joke to the class.

Step 2: Consequences

The consequences to the operant behaviour can be reinforce the behaviour or punish the organism into supressing the behaviour. For example, the class all laugh at the joke (positive reinforcement) or the student's good-standing is taken by the teacher because the joke was inappropriate and untimely (negative reinforcement). These consequences govern whether the behaviour occurs again. Using the same example, the student is more likely to tell another joke later if the class laughs at their joke. However, the student is unlikely to tell another joke to the class if their good-standing is revoked by the teacher as this is an unfavourable outcome to the student. If the class and teacher does not respond to their joke, the consequence becomes a neutral operant and has no influence on the likelihood of the behaviour.

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OPERANT CONDITIONING

Types of Consequences:

Reinforcement

- Reinforcement is an event that strengthens or increases the likelihood of the operant behaviour.

Positive Reinforcement

- Involves the addition of a favourable event (to the organism) in order to increase the likelihood of a behaviour occurring.
    - For example: giving your doggo a treat after sitting down

Negative Reinforcement

- Involves the removal of an unfavourable event in order to increase the likelihood of a behaviour occurring
    - For example: removing homeworking from students due to good behaviour

Punishment

- Punishment is the presentation of an unfavourable event that weakens or decreases likelihood of the operant behaviour.

Positive Reinforcement

- Involves the addition of an unfavourable event in order to decrease the likelihood of a behaviour occurring.
    - For example: spanking a child for misbehaviour

Negative Reinforcement

- Involves the removal of a favourable event in order to decrease the likelihood of a behaviour occurring
    - For example: teacher confiscates students phone after being caught using it at school.

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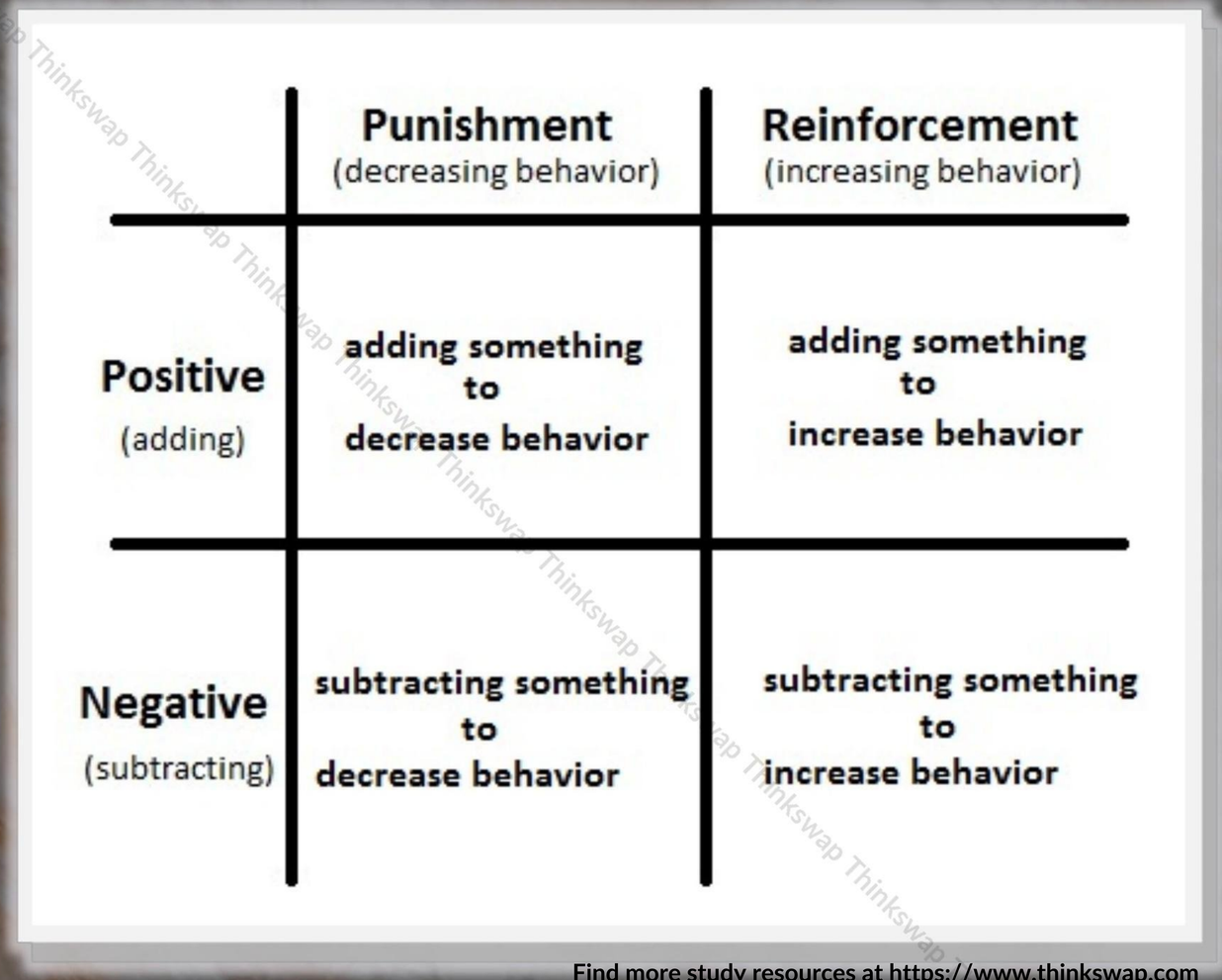
OPERANT CONDITIONING

Types of Consequences:

Neutral Responses

- An event where the behaviour is not encouraged or discouraged.
  - For example: a child is screaming at the supermarket, the parent chooses to ignore the child because he/she only wants to gain attention or is manipulating the parent into a reward such as chocolate.



	Punishment (decreasing behavior)	Reinforcement (increasing behavior)
Positive (adding)	**adding something to decrease behavior**	**adding something to increase behavior**
Negative (subtracting)	**subtracting something to decrease behavior**	**subtracting something to increase behavior**

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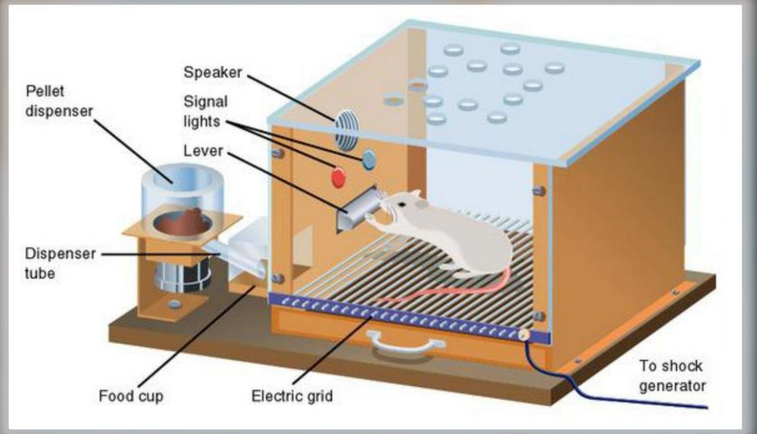
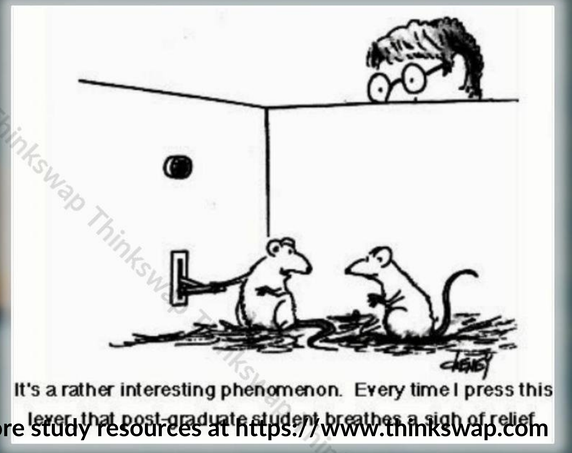
EVIDENCE FOR OPERANT CONDITIONING

SKINNER'S BOX

B.F. Skinner created 'Skinner's Box' (pictured to the right) in order to utilise as a conditioning chamber in his behavioural experiments on animals such as rats and pigeons.



In one of his most famous experiment in 1938, he observed the behaviour of a hungry rat within his box which contained a lever and empty walls. Once the rat got bored, it began to explore this lever and eventually pressed it. Each time the lever was pressed, food was ejected into the box and the rat repeated this action in order to release more food into the box. Through the positive reinforcement of food, the rat began to perform the behaviour more frequently as it made an association between the lever and food. Eventually, a light appeared when food was available for ejection into the box. If the rat pressed this lever when the light was not present, food would not be ejected. Soon enough, the rat learned that when the light came on, it could press the lever for a food reward.



Skinner was able to conclude that an organism's environment shapes their behaviour based on the consequences they received. He found that changes in behaviour are a response to stimuli and this is the methodology of how organisms naturally learn.

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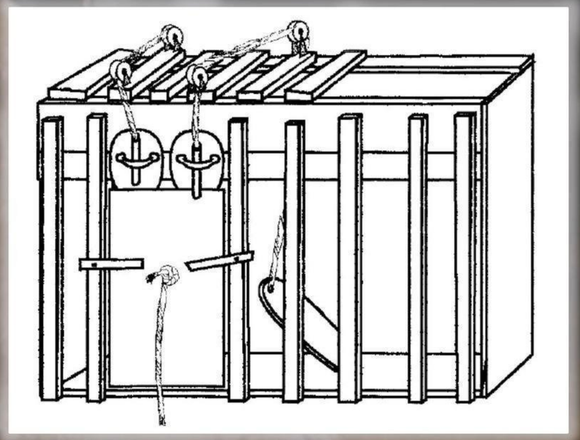
EVIDENCE FOR OPERANT CONDITIONING

THORNDIKE'S LAW OF EFFECT

B.F. Skinner's Operant Conditioning Theory was built on the ideas of Edward Thorndike. Thorndike devised the "Law of Effect" in 1898, which stated that "responses that produce a satisfying effect in a particular situation become more likely to occur again in that situation, and responses that produce a discomforting effect become less likely to occur again in that situation." (Gray, 2011, p. 108-109).

Thorndike developed a classical experiment in which a puzzle box (pictured to the right) was used to test the laws of learning. Thorndike usually placed a cat into this box and this cat was encouraged to escape eat a chunk of fish that was left outside of the box. Thorndike timed the duration taken for the cat to escape, as an empirical measure of learning.

The cat would eventually find a lever that would open the cage, and the cat was free to eat the fish. Thorndike placed the same cat back in the same box and repeated this experiment multiple times. This resulted in the cat learning that pressing the lever would result in favourable consequences. Thorndike observed that the cats would learn this behaviour and it would quicker in each subsequent trial.



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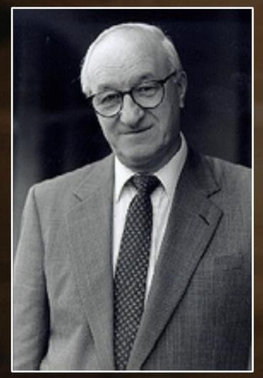
OBSERVATIONAL LEARNING



Observational learning was developed by psychologist Albert Bandura in 1961 through his bobo doll study in which he observed violent behaviour in children. Observational learning is the cognitive process whereby individuals learn behaviours, thoughts and feelings by observing others and evaluating whether or not imitating the behaviour is beneficial to them. It should be known that observational learning is not a type of associative learning.

Observational learning is not just simply imitating others; individuals learn from the behaviour of others too. These people who are being observed are known as a model. In children, role models have a major influence in their cognitive and behavioural development. This is evident through Bandura's Bobo Doll Study that will be mentioned in a further slide.

Observational learning is very applicable to developmental situations involving toddlers and children. For example, a baby learns how to walk by observing their parents or role models walking. Children also learn how to play sports through observing other players during games or training sessions.

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OBSERVATIONAL LEARNING

Observational learning involves four cognitive processes that are required for the learning to occur successfully:

- Attention: the subject must attend to the behaviour, the consequences that follow and the environmental condition in which the behaviour is performed in.
  - For example, a child watches a game of junior sports.

- Retention: the subject must have the attended behaviour stored in their memory for retrieval.
  - E.g. the child must have watched the sport multiple times to store it in their memory.

- Reproduction: the subject must have the physical and mental capabilities to replicate the behaviour.
  - E.g. the child must be old enough to perform all the movements required in the sport such as running, throwing etc.

- Motivation: the subject must have a reason to imitate behaviour – it can be from subject seeing reward given to observed others (extrinsic) or self-motivated (intrinsic).
  - E.g. the child may want to play with their friends, or for the medal at the end of the season.

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OBSERVATIONAL LEARNING

The Observational Learning Process

- Adapted by Damon in 1983

Modelled event or activity

Attentional Processes

Behaviour is noticed

Retention Processes

Behaviour is stored into memory

Motor Reproduction Processes

Involves physical skills
Capabilities influence extent
and accuracy of modelling

Motivational Processes

Rewards and reinforcement
from others or self

Reproduction of Behaviour

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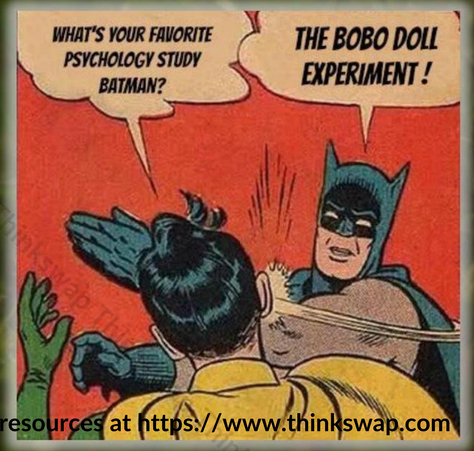
EVIDENCE FOR OBSERVATIONAL LEARNING

BANDURA'S BOBO DOLL STUDY

In 1961, Bandura performed an experiment that became the basis of research into observational learning. This experiment investigated whether aggression can be learned through observation. He conducted the experiment involving 72 children (50% male, 50% female) and tested their response to aggressive and non-aggressive role models. This was shown to the participants through a video where an individual was interacting with a blow up doll. One group was shown an aggressive video and the other was shown a video of peaceful interaction. After this, the children were placed into a room with a bobo doll and the child was able to play as they pleased. The results from this experiment show that the children who were exposed to the aggressive role model exhibited aggressive behaviour to the bobo doll. These findings support Bandura's Theory of Observational Learning as it shows that the social behaviour of children is learned through the observation of others.

Video games are a matter of concern for parents, as many believe that children can be influenced by the violence portrayed by characters within these games. This is also seen within mainstream media, such as movies and television shows.



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APPLICATION TO YOUR PET

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APPLICATION TO YOUR PET

So far we have covered the background information behind three major theories of learning; classical conditioning, operant conditioning and observational learning. These theories are extremely beneficial to training your pet, as you are now able to fully utilise this knowledge to your advantage in order to train your pet in the most effective method possible. **Let's transform your good boy into the goodest boy he can be!**

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APPLICATION: ROLLING OVER

Through the application of observational learning, you will be able to train your dog how to roll over! For this method t be successful, you must have another dog that can demonstrate the desired behaviour. This dog will be used as the model dog as he will perform the behaviour and receive the consequences, in order for your dog to observe and learn the behaviour.

To begin, you should ask the model dog to demonstrate the action of rolling over through a verbal command such as 'roll over!'. This dog should be given a plethora of treats and praises during his performance whilst your dog observes these consequences. Don't forget that your dog needs to fulfil the four cognitive processes in order to successfully learn the behaviour.

Ensure that your dogs attention is focused on the demonstration by providing treats and praises to the model dog whilst he demonstrates the desired behaviour. Hopefully, your dog should be retained this behaviour whilst he observes. Most dogs are very active and flexible, so he should be physically capable of reproducing the behaviour he observes unless he is injured. Your dog should also possess the motivation to perform the behaviour, which the positive reinforcement given in treats to the model dog should motivate your dog to perform the action.

After the observation process, ask your dog to 'roll over!'. He should, with a bit of luck and a stroke of genius, attempt to roll over by mimicking the actions be just observed. Ensure that he is provided with many treats, "good boys" and belly rubs if he performs the desired behaviour. You should practice this a few times in order to cement the idea in your goodest boys head.

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APPLICATION: STAY

Through the application of operant conditioning, you will be able to train your dog how to stay! Operant conditioning is utilised in this instance because you can reward or punish your dog for his behaviour. This can be an effective technique in order to teach your dog to make an association between a desired behaviour and the reinforcements/punishments.

To begin, you will need full attention from your furry friend. Afterwards, execute a verbal command by saying 'stay' in a clear and loud voice so that he can hear you. You then turn around and slowly walk away, checking behind you to see if he moves or stays in position. If he moves when your back is turned towards him, positively punish him by saying 'no' in a loud, angry tone. Afterwards, you turn around again and begin to slowly walk away, checking behind you once again. If he does not move for approximately 5-10 seconds, reward the boy with a tasty treat as positive reinforcement and praise him. Repeat this on a multiplicity of occasions in order for your dog to make the association between your command and his actions required to get a treat. After he begins to pick up on the association, begin to walk away for a larger distance or perform different activities where he is required to stay.

Eventually, your dog will perform the command you desired.

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APPLICATION: SIT

Through the application of classical conditioning, you will be able to train your dog how to sit! Classical conditioning is used in this instance as an association can be made between a neutral stimulus and an unconditioned stimulus to produce the conditioned response of sitting. In a natural sense, your dog will not feel the need to sit when verbally commanded to do so. But through using classical conditioning, the dog can be gradually guided to sitting over time.

Stage 1: Before Conditioning

Your dog will already desire any type of food or treat that is placed near him/hear and they will try to take it from your hand. There is a natural association between the treat (unconditioned stimulus) and the dog attempting to eat the food (unconditioned response). This can be manipulated into conditioning the dog to sit as the he/she tends to move towards the treat.

Stage 2: During Conditioning

Before the neutral stimulus is introduced, you should hold the treat up above your dogs head whilst they are highly focused. It should be taken up to the point where the dog will be forced to sit down. Before the dog sits, introduce a neutral stimulus of saying 'sit' in a clear voice. Once the dog sits, reinforce this behaviour by rewarding them with a treat. This should be repeated multiple times in order to build up an association between the neutral stimulus (verbal command of sitting) and being given a treat for doing the action. Don't forget to tell him that he's been a good boy!

Stage 3: After Conditioning

After your dog has learned the action of sitting, the neutral stimulus of verbally commanding the dog to sit will become to conditioned stimulus. The unconditioned response of your dog sitting will become to conditioned response. The dog should eventually begin to sit without the presence of a treat, which was the unconditioned stimulus. Your dog should be able to sit on command now!

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EFFECTIVENESS OF TRAINING METHODS

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EFFECTIVENESS OF CLASSICAL CONDITIONING

Classical Conditioning, in the context of dog behaviour training, is highly effective in teaching your dog how to perform simple behaviour such as sitting.

+ PROS

Classical Conditioning is an effective training method as it is a fairly basic theory and can be easily applied to training your pet. It can be utilised to modify unwanted behaviours, as it relies on an existing behaviour that is built upon and this can also be used to eradicate phobias. Dogs are able to recognise and associate between stimuli with ease, making this theory easy to apply. There is also a large amount of research and evidence further reinforcing the theory of Classical Conditioning.

- CONS

Classical Conditioning relies on a pre-existing behaviour; so the teaching of new behaviour is not applicable using this theory. Classical Conditioning is also limited to involuntary, natural reflexes so there are possible limitations as to what you can teach your furry buddy. The conditioning can also be easily forgotten and can be difficult to re-establish if there is too many stimuli or depleted motivation. Classical conditioning also ignores the biological influences involved in learning, depicting learning as being dependent on environmental stimuli.

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EFFECTIVENESS OF OPERANT CONDITIONING

Operant Conditioning, in the context of dog behaviour training, is also highly effective in teaching your dog. This is because it is provided on the basis of reinforcement/punishment in which is enjoyable for your dog if he receives a treat. There is an immediate consequence following their behaviour, in which increases the likelihood of this behaviour being repeated again in the near future.

+ PROS

Operant Conditioning is the easiest technique to train your pet to perform a desired behaviour. This is because there is a motivation behind performing the behaviour, whether it be a reward or punishment. You can integrate operant conditioning to get rid of unwanted behaviour as well. Unlike Classical Conditioning, new tricks and behaviours can be learned by your dog as it is not reliant on a pre-existing behaviour.

- CONS

Operant Conditioning ignores the influence of heredity and assumes that our little furry buddies have little control over their behaviour. It is also difficult to introduce complicated concepts, as it requires patience, effort and time. It can also be unethical on occasions based on the trainers idea of punishment such as hitting, yelling, throwing stuff etc. This will create more harm towards the dog, and will produce unwanted behaviour and fear which can impact your relationship with your dog.

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EFFECTIVENESS OF OBSERVATIONAL LEARNING

Observational Learning, in the context of dog behaviour training, is one of the least effective techniques to train your pet. It would be difficult to teach your pet an action through observation as they are required to meet the requirements of the four cognitive processes (Motivation, Attention, Reproduction and Retention).

+ PROS

Observational Learning is an optimistic theory that highlights the importance of role models on children, as well as masters on dogs. This theory can be utilised to predict future outcomes and can be a biological advantage to your pet. It is an almost effortless theory that is based on observation, in which is possibly where it's downfall occurs in relation to pet training. This theory is based on experience.

- CONS

Observational Learning possesses the disadvantage of having to find an appropriate model for your dog to follow during training. These models could produce unwanted behaviours in your dog, such as barking excessively. It can be difficult for your dog to achieve all the requirements for observational learning to be successful, as they are easily distracted, lack motivation when treats aren't available et.c

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